JPART 21:239–256

Does Stronger Political Leadership Have a Performance Payoff? Citizen Satisfaction in the Reform of Subcentral Governments in England

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ABSTRACT

An influential literature in urban political and public management debates whether political leadership, in particular the form of council government in the United States, can improve policy and other outcomes by providing coordination, control, and facilitation. The article tests whether stronger political leadership affects citizen satisfaction through the direct connection of leaders to citizens even when the possible effect of policy performance is controlled for. In addition, the article investigates whether majority and coalition governments mediate the impact of leadership. The data are drawn from English local authorities following a reform in 2000 that created separate executive bodies in councils and gave powers to political leaders. The analysis uses regression models on survey data from the English principal local authorities. The article concludes that leader powers predict citizen satisfaction but that single-party majority government does not. The article adds to the literature on the impact of the form of council government by setting out the mechanisms whereby leadership translates to positive citizen outcomes.

INTRODUCTION

Democrats are wary of giving political authority to one person because of the fear of the abuse of office, the possibility of corruption, the limitations of cognitive capacity, and the risk that stronger leaders may become detached from sources of intelligence, open debate, and even common sense. Instead, cross-checking institutions are supposed to promote effective policy making, avoid policy errors by promoting learning on the part of policy makers, and create a stronger sense of legitimacy.

We wish to acknowledge the contribution of our project colleagues Francesca Gains and Gerry Stoker and comments received at the Political Studies Association Annual Conference (2009), participants at the "Administration, Democracy and Performance" Symposium, Manchester 2008, and the Political Science and Political Economy Group Conference on "Designing Democratic Institutions" London School of Economics 2008, as well as the comments of three anonymous referees. The data used in this research were collected as part of an official evaluation of the Local Government Act 2000. We are grateful for the support; however, the findings in this article are the sole responsibility of the authors. Address correspondence to the author at s.greasley@uea.ac.uk.

doi:10.1093/jopart/muq018
Advance Access publication on May 19, 2010
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But what if giving power to one leader without the constraints of interparty coalitions leads to greater public satisfaction and a stronger citizen connection? It may be possible for leaders who are unconstrained by interparty negotiation to use extra powers to get things done and to have a more direct relationship with the electorate. Is this dangerous, but worth the risk? In spite of a lot of recent literature about leadership (e.g., Poguntke and Webb 2005) and extensive reform across the world, especially at the local level (Larsen 2005; Steyvers et al. 2008), there are few tests of the impact of leadership powers on citizens' perceptions and almost none on how these powers interact with their political contexts (for an exception, see Cusack 1999). Do coalitions constrain the misuse of power by leaders or do one-party governments rule better and with more satisfied citizens? Such considerations go to the heart of a key question in urban institutional design: whether reforms that increase powers of the leader foster the public good.

This article tests for the impact of stronger forms of leadership using data from constitutional reforms in English local government. It seeks to provide evidence on whether strengthening the position of local leaders improves citizens' views about the performance of councils. The first section deals with the reform of urban political leadership and policy performance and outlines our expectations of the impact of leader powers. Then we briefly describe the English local government system and make explicit three propositions linking leader powers to citizen satisfaction. The data and methods are described in the third section. The fourth section assesses whether an association can be found between the different ways the reforms were adopted and the satisfaction of citizens with their councils' services. Finally, we draw some implications of the impact of the power of leaders for the reform of urban government.

INSTITUTIONS, POLICY PERFORMANCE, AND CITIZEN ENGAGEMENT

The Research Evidence

There is a long line of literature from US urban politics that suggests that strong mayoral structures should be able to deliver performance improvements (e.g., Kotter and Lawrence 1974). The hypothesized contrast is between council manager systems where the council members appoint the manager and mayor-council municipalities where there is direct election of both the mayor and the council. The key argument for the leadership advocates is that if the mayor is independent of the council, then they will have the incentive to chivvy the professional bureaucrats. Svara (1987, 210) cogently summarizes this point of view, "if the mayor does not activate the lethargic city government or give it direction, no other elected official will. The manager, they suggest, will manipulate the council, pursue a personal professional agenda, and take cues from outside influentials but will not provide leadership responsive to elected officials or supportive of their exercise of democratic control."

There are many studies looking at leadership form and urban outcomes. The early studies (e.g., Lineberry and Fowler 1967) show that council-manager systems produce lower levels of taxation and expenditure and are less responsive to citizen input than mayor-council systems. Later research using more sophisticated tests finds there to be no effect of governmental structures on taxation and spending (Deno and Mehay 1987; Jung 2006; Morgan and Pelissero 1980). Morgan and Watson (1995), using a large sample of cities, find no difference either. On the other hand, Haughwout and Inman (2002) analyze the effects of weak city governance—where there is an institutionally weak mayor along with

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district-representing council members—finding detrimental effects on home value and income growth. This suggests a lack of leadership from the center can reduce the long-term benefits to the citizen. But the research evidence is not uniform. For example, Stumm and Corrigan (1998) conclude that council-manager cities have lower taxes and expenditure. Nunn's (1996) investigation into the differences in spending between council-manager and mayor-council cities according to functional area finds that council-manager cities allocate more to water, sewer, and road infrastructure, a reflection of the professional training and longer time horizons of appointed (rather than elected) managers and again shows how variation in leadership can lead to variation in time horizons in municipal decision making. However, Rauch (1995) found that council-manager cities spent less on infrastructure than did mayor-council cities. The problem is that studies use different methods to produce different results, which means it is not possible to draw firm conclusions (Frederickson et al. 2004).

Of course spending decisions may not capture all aspects of performance though they have the advantage of being easily measured and compared. Giroux and McLelland (2003) find that city manager systems outperform mayor council systems in the production and publication of financial information, helping accountability. Clark and Ferguson (1983) show that "new" fiscally populist mayors tend to be preoccupied with efficiency programs and new kinds of social policies (see also Schneider and Teske 1992). Ferman (1985) concludes that strong mayors are more responsive to the public and favor more equitable distribution of resources.

Overall, the evidence of a policy difference between the two systems is weak (see Welch and Bledsoe 1988 for a review). The reason may be that the two systems do not differ so much on the leaders' formal powers and as such do not generate fair evaluations of different forms of leadership. In addition, the blurring of the two systems makes it difficult to draw conclusions about the impact of institutions (Frederickson et al. 2004). There has been less work on the effect of leadership in the English context. Andrews, Boyne, and Enticott (2006) assess the influence of political leadership on a performance measure derived from inspection scores and find a positive relationship. However, their measure of the quality of political leadership is based on the subjective assessments of managers and politicians rather than a measure of leaders' institutional position.

There is much less literature on whether leadership form directly affects citizen satisfaction and this is where the current article contributes. Here the idea is that greater clarity of responsibility should lead to a better connection between citizens' preferences and policy, with the implication that citizens would be more satisfied as a result. There is some evidence from the policy-opinion literature that citizens who perceive a clear responsibility of government, among other things enhanced by presidentialialism, tend to be able to punish and reward incumbents (Soroka and Wlezien 2008). At the local level, Cusack (1999) tests the leadership proposition in Germany, exploiting variation in the strength of mayors and finds that citizen satisfaction is associated with stronger leadership. There is no US literature testing the impact of leadership on citizen satisfaction; however, the US literature agrees that council manager and mayor-council systems face different constituency pressures (Morgan and Watson 1995). Not all the literature supports arguments that relate strengthened leadership to greater citizen satisfaction, however, such as the idea that satisfaction with democracy is related to the way in which different systems create winners or losers (Anderson and Guillory 1997)—in cases where the leader is more powerful and there is a majority, this may depress citizen approval.

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Overall, the literature on urban leadership is not satisfactory because it does not consider the causal mechanisms whereby leadership leads to improved outcomes. In this article, we test specifically whether leadership has a direct effect on satisfaction, that is, one that is additional to an effect that might work via organizational performance. The section below outlines the theoretical argument that justifies this focus. A second distinctive feature of the analysis is that the article examines the effects of different aspects of leadership power rather than only comparing "strong" with "weak" leadership.

The Theoretical Argument

Leaders often have powers that are constitutional in nature. The powers are to do with appointments and the degree of independence the leader has over the policy process. There are good reasons to expect these powers to enhance the leader's freedom and as a consequence help deliver effective policy outcomes. The powers may put a person in the driving seat who has a stronger connection to the voter and so is keen to improve the delivery of services as part of that mission or the person may be predisposed to introduce new policies and use those powers to deliver them effectively. The expectation here is that greater powers may be used to shape the internal command and control mechanisms within the bureaucracy by keeping bureaucratic actors in check, managing governing coalitions and providing a robust framework for policy delivery and evaluation. It may be the case that within the bureaucracy there are those who would otherwise be able to block new policy initiatives to protect their service fiefdoms but whose influence may be limited by leaders with more powers. This is backed up by studies of council managers. As Morgan and Watson (1995, 232) write, "research focusing on the leadership role of mayors within council-manager government reveals that factors such as direct election, longer tenure, possession of veto power, and authority over the council agenda affords the chief executive additional political leverage." On the other hand, as shown in Svara's (1987) work, it is the informal differences that count.

The second leg of the reformist argument is the interaction between these powers and the political contexts in which they operate. Coalition governments tend to break down and complicate command and control mechanisms. They may dilute the coherence of policy delivery, creating multiple principals for the bureaucrats to work to. Even if the political leader is constitutionally powerful, it may not be possible to push through reforms with such alacrity if other parties have the potential to block them. Other things being equal, we would expect coalition governments to moderate the impact of leader powers.

The third and final leg to the argument is that where leaders have more powers citizens may have a more direct relationship to those in political authority—there may be an effect over and above any improvements in the performance of services. Voters may see the clarity of responsibility and like the ability to allocate blame or credit to a single politician. Armed with stronger powers, the leader may be able to cultivate a relationship with the general public directly and through the media, based on his or her visibility and personality. With someone to hold responsible or to give credit, the argument is that citizens should be more satisfied because they can seek redress if things go wrong and see the links between their actions as voters and decisions made to change service delivery. In this way, the public may rate the performance of a single leader more highly than a collective body. This argument also applies to the perception of context too. Where leaders do not need to negotiate

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with coalition partners, the public may be able to perceive leaders' actions more clearly and approve of this extra clarity.

In the context of modern urban government, there are two specific ways that this direct relationship might operate. The first is that much of the work of local political leaders occurs beyond the institutional boundary of local government. They must draw together and steer resources from a variety of public and private actors and their success in doing this will not necessarily be apparent in the measurable outputs of the local authority. The growing literature on facilitative leadership suggests that it is the connection to diverse partners that is the main factor behind leadership success (Svara 2008). The second is that the leader may be able to tailor the provision of services more in line with citizen demands and so increase citizens' satisfaction.

With these elements in play, our argument suggests that there are two drivers of performance—one relates to the technical efficiency of the management of the tools of implementation and the other is to do with the direct relationship between the leader and the public. They link through the way in which improved performance is perceived and evaluated by the individual citizen and the way in which leaders are driven by public responsiveness to prioritize resources in line with citizens' preferences. It should be noted that these two processes are complementary—they can work together to form a win-win type of leadership. But they also suggest different causal mechanisms. In one, the leadership impact is direct through a relationship to the citizens who approve of policies and decisions and the other is indirect through the control of bureaucracy and effective implementation that in turn gains citizens' approval (Van Ryzin et al. 2004). If the bins are being collected on time, people are likely to be satisfied. Here, we are primarily interested in the first of these mechanisms, the direct effect of leadership on satisfaction. The impact of context may affect both processes as coalitions reduce the control of the leader over policy and impair the clarity of responsibility in the citizens' eyes.

Our arguments lead to three distinct empirical questions. First, we ask whether the strength of leadership position as a whole has an impact on citizens' sense of satisfaction with the performance of local government services, in addition to any benefit that may be derived from having single-party majority control. Second, we ask whether stronger leadership can have an effect above and beyond that which operates via independently measured organizational performance. Third, we disaggregate the effect of leadership powers on citizens' satisfaction, comparing the power to allow leaders to make autonomous decisions with those powers that allow leaders to facilitate and manage the performance of an organization through their cabinets. To summarize, we test three propositions in our analysis:

Proposition 1: Councils where leaders have stronger institutional positions are better able to increase the proportion of citizens' satisfied with their activities. There is an effect that is additional to any associated with split versus single-party leadership.

Proposition 2: Stronger leadership has an effect that is partly independent of the measured performance of service delivery.

Proposition 3: Powers that allow leaders to manage the performance of others in an authority are more important than those that allow leaders autonomous decisions.

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CONTEXT

Our data come from subcentral governments in England and we use variations in the formal leadership powers and the difference between majority and nonmajority councils to measure the institutional position of political leaders. Local government in England is quite typical of European subcentral authorities where local elections run under party labels and determine political control. Local political leaders, as heads of the majority party or the leaders of a coalition, have a privileged position from which to influence policy and performance within guidelines set by central government and subject to a policy framework agreed annually by the council as a whole.

Until recently, there were no constitutionally separate executive bodies in English local governments, and decisions were often taken behind the scenes or in labyrinthine committee structures. The situation changed when a legislative reform in 2000 created separate executive cabinets. When the legislation was passed councils were given a number of choices about how they implemented the reforms. The most radical option—of having a directly elected mayor—was selected by only 12 authorities—but in this analysis, we study the councils that adopted the leader and cabinet model. With this form, council leaders are elected by members of the council on a yearly basis, but where the party political balance is stable enough, leaders often serve for many years and over successive electoral contests.[1]

Authorities operating a leader and cabinet system have three key choices about which powers to give to their leaders. They can give leaders: the power to select—and dismiss—the members of their cabinets or reserve that power for the full council, the power to allocate portfolios among cabinet members or reserve that power for the full council, and the executive power to make certain decisions alone. These indicators capture different aspects of leadership power. The first two can be seen as instruments for channeling accountability for political decisions and administrative performance toward the leader, giving her or him the power to discipline and manage the performance of executive colleagues. The power of appointment and removal is a crucial weapon for leaders who wish to influence policy and implementation in a complex setting. It allows leaders to delegate responsibility to carefully selected politicians and to manage the rewards and sanctions their appointees face. The third power provides leaders with direct decision-making power although the range of decisions may vary from council to council.[2] This indicator reflects as more direct understanding of the concentration of power with leaders being granted discretion to make decisions, whereas the former type of mechanism is more associated with facilitative styles of leadership, allowing leaders to place trusted allies in key positions and to give them the responsibility for developing and delivering strategies. In the case of multipurpose local authorities in complex policy environments, where it is difficult for an individual leader to stay on top of all aspects of a bureaucracy's work, we expect appointment powers to be more important than individual decision making.

Although the extent of the institutional reforms and the variation between authorities may seem minor, there is evidence that those that work in the system saw changes in the operation of organizations fairly soon after the reforms were implemented. A survey of

1 Subsequent legislation has changed the term to 4-year terms, although a majority on the full council can still remove the leader.

2 All executive decisions are taken within the bounds set by the "policy and budget framework" adopted by the full council.

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councillors, local authority bureaucrats, and staff from other local public agencies conducted in 2003 and covering 40 local authorities provides evidence that even in the first years of the operation of the system leaders developed higher public profiles and were perceived to be stronger than they were prior to the reforms (Stoker et al. 2004). A repeat of that survey in 2005 found that in those councils where leaders' were given more power, respondents were more likely to believe decision making had become quicker, that the role of the leader was stronger, and the leader had a higher public profile (Gains et al. 2007a, table 2, 18). However, the picture on transparency and openness is more mixed with some indication that the policy process might be viewed to be less open where leadership powers are stronger.

The perception found from survey data that changes to leadership powers have made a difference is backed up in another report using qualitative interviews conducted between 2003 and 2006 in 10 local authorities (Gains 2006). The report quotes the top bureaucrat of a large county council: "the leader is assertive and effective and the cabinet a smaller group of people who trust each other—the Act makes it easier to get things done rather than get lost in committees" (Gains 2006, 9). The same report argues that authorities with more concentrated forms of leadership find it easier to shift resources and adapt to changing circumstances.

The evidence from interviews and the elite surveys supports the view that the adoption of cabinet systems has made a difference to important aspects of the operation of local councils. In addition, there is evidence that the particular way that leaders operate in relation to their cabinet and councils may be important. That research hints at an important impact of institutional variation on council operations and performance. The evidence we present here builds on these results by testing for the effects of institutional variations on citizens' satisfaction over a larger number of cases. The overall argument for a positive effect of stronger leader powers can then draw from a wide range of methods, both quantitative and qualitative, that generate complementary findings.

DATA AND MODELING STRATEGY

Dependent and Key Independent Variables

Our data on institutional characteristics were collected via a postal survey sent to all 148 principal local authorities in England asking a series of questions about the way that the local authority operates.[3] The survey was conducted in 2002—just after the implementation of the legislation that imposed cabinet government—and again in 2006. The survey received 102 valid responses in the first round and 103 in the second—76 responded in both years (summary statistics of the variables we use in the models are reported in table 1—in each wave we lose one council due to missing performance data). The ability of leaders to influence the policy process is not determined only by the constitutional rules in an organization; the political context may also be of importance. In 2002, 25% of the top-tier authorities that responded to our survey had no majority party in control and the figure remained virtually unchanged (26%) in the 2006 survey.

The two other variables of key interest to us are the measures of citizen satisfaction and organizational performance. Our models predict the proportion of citizens satisfied with "the way the council runs things," the exact wording of the question is reproduced

3 For details of the survey, see Gains et al. (2007b).

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Figure 1
Best Value Survey Question

1. Under a subsection in the survey titled 'Other Services':
a. Taking everything into account, how satisfied or dissatisfied are you with the way the authority runs things?
Very satisfied/Fairly satisfied/ Neither satisfied or dissatisfied/ Fairly dissatisfied/ Very dissatisfied

in figure 1. The data are collected as part of a nationally consistent and audited performance management framework operated by the Audit Commission—an independent public body. Every 3 years, local authorities are required to conduct a survey of households with a standardized questionnaire and methodology and are each required to achieve a sample size of at least 1,100 (Annex B, DCLG, 2007). The data are only published after they have been aggregated at local authority level—we model the proportion of citizens in each authority that answered the question positively, that is, the proportion that were very or fairly satisfied. The question has been asked three times—in 2000, 2003, and 2006. We use lagged measures of the dependent variable as controls and also exploit the repeated measurement to explore the length of lags between leadership position and change in satisfaction.

As well as controlling for past levels of citizen satisfaction, we also enter a general indicator of council performance. As our discussion above explains, we are interested in exploring whether strong leadership has an effect on citizen satisfaction in addition to that which can be attributed to improvements in measurable organizational performance. To measure service performance, we use data from the Comprehensive Performance Assessment (CPA), an annual summary judgment of council services and capacity produced by the Audit Commission. We use a subset of the CPA, the "core service performance" (CSP), which assesses the performance of key services (education, social services, environment, housing, libraries and leisure, benefits). On this measure, scores are based on both inspectors' judgments and audited performance indicators that are consistently collected across authorities. However, unlike the full CPA, they do not include inspectors' assessments of the overall management capacity in an authority. The CSP is a weighted average of scores from each service with education and social services receiving the greatest weight. However, one group of authorities in our data set—the county councils—performs fewer functions than the others. To make the measure comparable across all the authorities, the CSP score is based on the percentage of the maximum possible score for each type of authority (more details about the performance framework and the CSP score used can be found in Andrews et al. 2005).[4]

Modeling Strategy

Inferring causality from nonexperimental data is notoriously difficult. However, we can explore patterns in the available observational data thoroughly and come to a judgment about whether they are consistent or not with posited causal relationships. Here we use

4 We wish to thank Nicolai Petrovsky (University of Kentucky), formerly at University of Wales Cardiff, for providing us with this data.

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conditional change models of citizen satisfaction, controlling for baseline position by adding a previous wave's satisfaction score as a control variable. In effect, we are modeling the relative change in satisfaction rather than the absolute level of satisfaction. This approach allows the coefficient of the lagged dependent variable to be determined by the model rather than being assumed to be equal to one as would be the case if we modeled the change score directly (Markus, 1979, 47–8).

It is difficult to judge a priori the appropriate length of the lag between the measurements of leadership structure and the dependent variable. Modeling the relationship between leadership position and the relative change in satisfaction rather than the absolute level of satisfaction means that we are able to be more confident about shorter lags than if we did not include a previous wave's satisfaction score as a control. We do explore the appropriate lags by using leadership powers in 2002 to predict 2003 satisfaction and then repeat the model for 2006 satisfaction. We also report a model of satisfaction in 2006 as predicted by leadership powers in 2006.

Control Variables

We seek to control for the environment in which local authorities find themselves. First, we control for the size of a council in terms of (logged) population. Recent analysis has suggested that larger councils may benefit from economies of scale in the provision of services—we would therefore expect there to be a positive effect from larger populations on satisfaction with services (Andrews, Boyne, Chen, and Martin 2006). But older evidence suggests just the opposite—that citizen satisfaction should be greater in smaller jurisdiction because jurisdictions compete to maximize citizen benefit (Mouritzen 1989). Likewise, evidence indicates that smaller sized local councils are generally trusted by a greater proportion of the population (Denters, 2002). To measure the size of councils, we use official mid-year population estimates and take their natural logs. A second control variable we use is the authority average index of multiple deprivation (IMD) 2004. This is an official measure of area deprivation derived largely from data collected by the 2001 census—the "2004" refers to the date of its publication. Authorities that face a more challenging social environment—as indicated by the deprivation index—may have more difficulty satisfying their citizens. We control for three aspects of population diversity in an authority. Specifically, we include variables to capture ethnic diversity, age diversity, and the geographical diversity of social conditions within a local authority area. For ethnic diversity, we use a dummy variable based on the percentage of the population that is white with the median (95%) as the cut-point. For age diversity initially, we generated a Herfindahl index based on four age groups—0–19, 20–39, 40–59 (–64 [male]), and 60 or above (65 or above [male]) The reasoning behind this broad age categorization is that school-aged children (0–19) and retired adults (60 or above for female and 65 or above for male) make particular demands on local authority services. We then split the remaining adults in half. This variable is very skewed and again we use a dummy variable cut at the median.[5] Measures of

5 This approach may mask some of the variation in these variables. We also tried the models with the undichotomized "age" and "ethnicity" variables, and the key significance tests are generally robust. The exceptions are model 5 where "portfolio allocation" moves from being marginally significant to marginally nonsignificant at the 5% level when the nondichotomized variables are used and models 3 and 4 where the leadership variables move from marginally nonsignificant to marginally significant (all at the 5% level).

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Table 1
Descriptive Statistic

	Mean	SD	Minimum, Maximum	*N*
Dependent variables				
Satisfaction 2003	52.69	8.61	32, 76	101
Satisfaction 2006	51.61	5.72	42, 77	102
Independent variables				
Majority 02	0.752	0.434	0, 1	101
Majority 06	0.735	0.443	0, 1	102
2002 Leader has power to:				
Select cabinet	0.297	0.459	0, 1	101
Allocate portfolios	0.485	0.502	0, 1	101
Make decisions	0.396	0.491	0, 1	101
2006 Leader has power to:				
Select cabinet	0.412	0.495	0, 1	102
Allocate portfolios	0.607	0.491	0, 1	102
Make decisions	0.422	0.496	0, 1	102
Leadership indicator 2002	1.178	1.024	0, 3	101
Leadership indicator 2006	1.441	1.040	0, 3	102
Control variables				
Log population 2003	12.569	0.653	10.48, 14.11	101
Log population 2006	12.588	0.604	11.51, 14.12	102
Deprivation index 2002[a]	22.700	9.090	6.62, 46.57	101
Deprivation index 2006[a]	23.150	9.650	5.09, 49.78	102
Satisfaction 2000	60.248	7.852	44, 78	101
CSP 2002	66.543	8.777	46.67, 88.33	101
Average CSP 2002–05	69.169	6.848	50.83, 86.25	102
Diversity: ethnic 2002[a]	0.446	0.500	0, 1	101
Diversity: ethnic 2006[a]	0.441	0.500	0, 1	102
Geographical inequality 2002[a]	11.973	4.095	2.68, 20.90	101
Geographical inequality 2006[a]	12.180	4.086	4.18, 20.71	102
Diversity: age 2002[a]	0.514	0.502	0, 1	101
Diversity: age 2006[a]	0.480	0.502	0, 1	102
London (2006 models)	0.225	0.420	0, 1	102

[a]These are the same variable but the particular authorities that responded to the two rounds of the surveys differed.

income inequality within local authority boundaries are not available as no question is asked in the census about income. As an alternative, we use the within-authority standard deviation of the IMD score referred to above. The IMD is measured at geographical units called lower super output areas, and there are 32,488 such units distributed across the 148 councils that make up the top-tier of English local government. On average, each council has over 200 units at which a deprivation score is measured. We use the within council standard deviation of these scores as a measure of diversity of socioeconomic conditions.

Table 1 provides summary statistics for all the variables used in the models.

Before we proceed to the results, we need to bear in mind some of the limitations on the inferences that can be made from this type of data. It may be the case that the leaders who were popular or had more satisfied citizens in the first place were able to select greater powers (though we do control for prior satisfaction in the regressions). Furthermore, it might be argued that government organizations can be slow to respond to changes in

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Table 2
Political Leadership and Citizen Satisfaction (OLS)

	Wave 1 Respondents		Wave 2 Respondents	
Outcome Variable	1 (2003 Score)	2 (2006 Score)	3 (2006 Score)	4 (2006 Score)
Log population 2003	1.442 (1.14)			
Log population 2006		−0.925 (−1.6)	−1.520* (−2.07)	−0.403 (−0.53)
London dummy				4.503** (3.11)
Deprivation	0.212 (1.41)	0.140 (1.68)	0.014 (0.2)	0.05 (0.6)
Satisfaction 2000	0.422** (3.69)	0.218** (4.08)		0.230** (3.29)
Satisfaction 2003			0.292* (4.34)	1.845** (3.69)
(Satisfaction 2003)^2				−1.01* (−2.16)
Diversity: ethnic	−0.230 (−0.12)	1.181 (1.07)	1.180 (1.17)	0.292 (0.26)
Diversity: age	−0.911 (−0.51)	1.893 (1.91)	0.650 (0.64)	0.879 (0.87)
Geographical inequality	−0.258 (−0.80)	−0.247 (−1.17)	−0.069 (−0.36)	0.038 (0.18)
CSP 2002	0.080 (0.84)			
Average CSP 2002−05		0.421** (5.00)	0.273** (3.19)	0.181* (2.59)
Majority control 2002	0.782 (0.43)			
Majority control 2006		2.180 (1.96)	0.557 (0.49)	−0.372 (−0.35)
Leader position 2002	2.086* (2.65)	0.800 (1.6)		
Leader position 2006			0.870 (1.98)	0.810 (1.94)
Constant	−0.428 (−0.02)	16.470 (1.71)	34.36** (2.91)	25.951* (2.14)
Observed	101	101	102	102
R^2/adjusted R^2	.31/.24	.52 (robust SE)	.44 (robust SE)	.55/.49

Note: OLS, ordinary least squares.
*$p < .05$; **$p < .01$ (t values in parenthesis).

the way they are organized and that it should take even longer for citizens to notice a difference in democratic organizations. The available data provide us with some limited opportunity, which we exploit, to assess the impact of leadership with different time lags.

Of course, there may be a more complex causal structure in the data than can be expressed by linear regression models and a panel might give greater understanding of the causal relationships, if any were to exist. There may be different aspects to stronger leadership than the measures captured in this study. That said, the article represents an important step in analyzing the link between the strength of leaders' positions in local democracies, the different structures of leadership, and citizens' satisfaction.[6]

RESULTS

The first questions we address are whether the overall strength of leadership is related to citizen satisfaction (proposition 1) and whether there is an effect that is partly independent of service performance (proposition 2). Models 1–4 in table 2 address these questions. The first model predicts satisfaction in 2003 using leadership position in 2002 along with the majority status of the council in 2002 and a number of controls. Model 2 uses the same covariates but models the proportion of citizens satisfied in 2006 as a function of leadership

6 Given our hypothesis is unidirectional, we could use one-tailed tests, but we retain the more stringent and conventional two-tailed tests in the reported models but we also report the p values of the key tests in the text.

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position in 2002 to provide some evidence on how long-lasting effects might be. Finally, we regress satisfaction in 2006 on leadership position in 2006 using two different specifications. Note, however, that models 1 and 2 use the first wave of the survey of institutional features, whereas models 3 and 4 use the second wave—the authorities that responded to wave one were not identical to those that responded in wave two.

Turning to model 1, none of the control variables are statistically significant with the exception that, as expected, the levels of satisfaction in 2000 did exert an influence on satisfaction in 2003. The position of the leader in 2002 is positively associated with satisfaction in 2003 and the coefficient is statistically significantly different from zero ($p = .01$) with the majority/nonmajority status of the council and the CSP 2002 score controlled for.[7] Authorities where leaders had stronger positions in 2002 on average generated a higher proportion of satisfied citizens taking into account their initial starting point and the other controls. For each additional power, a council is estimated to gain two percentage points in the proportion of citizens satisfied. This compares to less than one percentage point for moving from a multiparty to a single-party majority. The difference between an authority with no leadership powers and one with all three is estimated to be 6.25 percentage points and this is approximately equal to three-quarters of a standard deviation of the outcome variable.

Model 2 reports a similar model but this time using leadership position in 2002 to predict satisfaction in 2006. With this model, there are indications of heteroskedasticity and so we use robust standard errors. The controls are similar to those in model 1 with the exception that we now control for log population size in 2006, the majority status of the council in 2006, and the average service performance score 2002–2005. In this model, the coefficient of leader position remains positive but it is smaller than in model 1 and is no longer statistically significant at the 5% level ($p = .113$). There have also been some changes in the coefficients of other variables. Age diversity and deprivation now both have positive coefficients, also model 2 uses the average service performance score between 2002 and 2005, and this is strongly significant in the model. Majority control in 2006 in this specification is also positive but is not significant at the 5% level ($p = .053$).

We turn now to models using data from the second wave of the survey and predicting citizen satisfaction in 2006. Models 3 and 4 in Table 2 use those authorities that responded to the second wave of the survey and so the results are not directly comparable to models 1 and 2. Model 3 predicts satisfaction levels in 2006 using the position of leaders in 2006. There are indications of heteroskedasticity in this model and so we use robust standard errors. The coefficient of the leader position variable is positive but not statistically significant at the 5% level ($p = .05$). In model 3, satisfaction in 2003 is positively associated with satisfaction in 2006, but the size of a council's population dampens satisfaction levels. Service performance is the only other variable that is statistically significant. However, model 3 (and model 2) generates highly statistically significant results from Ramsey's RESET tests, indicating that the model may be misspecified. Examination of the residuals suggests that the London borough councils have performed particularly well over the period we study and a dummy variable "London" is entered into model 4 to control for this effect.

7 As well as testing direct effects of leadership position and majority councils, we also ran models testing for interactions between these variables. The interaction term was nonsignificant in all the models with the exception of model 3. As discussed below, there is evidence that model 3 is misspecified—model 4 is better and its interaction term is nonsignificant.

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This is positive and statistically significant at the 1% level ($p = .002$).[8] We also use model 4 to explore further the effects of lagged performance score by including both satisfaction in 2000 and in 2003 as controls and both are significant at the 1% level ($p = .001$ and $p = .000$, respectively). A positive RESET test can sometimes indicate that there are nonlinear relationships in the data and the squared 2003 satisfaction score is also statistically significant ($p = .034$) when entered, but the relationship is negative.[9] This suggests that those authorities that did extremely well in 2003 moved more toward the center of the distribution over the period to 2006. These additional controls remove the heteroskedasticity and ease the specification problems (although the RESET tests remains just significant at the 10% level). With the inclusion of these variables, the effect of service performance on satisfaction is less strong but still statistically significant ($p = .01$) and the coefficient of leaders' position changes very little but is not statistically significant at the 5% level ($p = .056$). It is difficult to make a comparison with confidence across the two waves; the model specification has changed, there is less variance in the 2006 measure of citizen satisfaction compared to 2003, and in the second wave of data, the position of leaders tends to be stronger than the first wave (see table 1).

The models in table 2 provide some evidence of a positive effect of leadership position on citizen satisfaction. The relevant variable is always positive but is only statistically significant at the 5% level in model 1.

Our third proposition is that different types of leadership power might have different relationships with citizen satisfaction. In particular, we are interested in the comparing individualized decision-making power that may be given to leaders with powers to manage the other players in the policy process.[10] We investigate these relationships in table 3 models 5–8 that use the first wave of the survey to predict satisfaction in 2003. Model 5 uses only the single power to allocate portfolios as the measure of leadership. Where authorities give this power to leaders rather than to the council as a whole, there is a positive effect on citizen satisfaction. The estimate in the model is that the proportion of citizens satisfied increases by 3.4 percentage points where leaders have this power and this is statistically significantly different from zero at the 5% level ($p = .043$). A similar story can be told when leaders have the power to appoint their cabinet rather than having it decided by a majority on the council (model 6). When leaders have that power, the proportion of citizens satisfied increases by an estimated 4.5 percentage points and the coefficient is again statistically significantly different from zero at the 5% level ($p = .013$). These two results contrast, however, with effects of giving leaders the power to take executive decisions alone (model 7). The estimated coefficient is approximately half the size of that for portfolio allocation and is not statistically significantly different from zero at the 5% level ($p = .315$). The models suggest that the powers given to leaders to manage others in the policy process by selecting and removing cabinet members and by allocating portfolios have positive effects, whereas the power to make decisions does not. Unsurprisingly, these three leadership powers are correlated with each other, and when all are included in the same model (model 8), none are statistically significantly different from zero.

8 Twenty-three of the authorities in the data set are London authorities.

9 We use orthogonalized transformations of Satisfaction 2003 and (Satisfaction 2003)^2 in model 4 (and also 8–10 below). The transformation effectively removes the "effect" of Satisfaction 2003 from (Satisfaction 2003)^2.

10 It should be noted that virtually all the councils that allow leaders to select the cabinet also allow her to allocate portfolios; however, the opposite is not the case.

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Table 3
Disaggregated Leadership Power and Citizen Satisfaction 2003 (OLS)

Outcome	Satisfaction 2003			
Model	5	6	7	8
Log population 2003	1.543 (1.21)	1.670 (1.32)	1.565 (1.20)	1.528 (1.20)
Deprivation	0.185 (1.22)	0.177 (1.18)	0.185 (1.19)	0.199 (1.30)
Satisfaction 2000	0.431** (3.70)	0.463** (4.10)	0.464** (3.96)	0.433** (3.70)
Diversity: ethnic	0.047 (0.02)	0.415 (0.22)	−0.566 (−0.29)	0.154 (0.08)
Diversity: age	−1.226 (−0.66)	−1.401 (−0.77)	0.077 (0.04)	−1.367 (−0.72)
Geographical inequality	−0.269 (−0.82)	−0.154 (−0.48)	−0.197 (−0.60)	−0.226 (−0.69)
CSP 2002	0.082 (0.85)	0.051 (0.52)	0.107 (1.09)	0.062 (0.63)
Majority 2002	1.210 (0.66)	0.630 (0.34)	1.409 (0.76)	0.634 (0.34)
Allocate portfolio 2002	3.372* (2.05)			1.749 (0.92)
Select cabinet 2002		4.537* (2.54)		3.356 (1.59)
Decision-making power 2002			1.688 (1.01)	1.014 (0.61)
Constant	−1.070 (−0.06)	−3.014 (−0.16)	−5.384 (−0.29)	−0.610 (−0.03)
Observed	101	101	101	101
R^2/adjusted	.29/.22	.31/.24	.27/.19	.31/.23

Note: OLS, ordinary least squares.
*$p < .05$; **$p < .01$ (t values in parenthesis).

A similar analysis was conducted for the second wave of the survey, predicting satisfaction in 2006 (table 4). These models have poorer diagnostics—all suffer from heteroskedasticity and model 11 produces a highly significant RESET test statistic and model 9 also generates a marginally significant RESET test statistic, even with the adjusted model specification discussed earlier.

In the models of 2006 satisfaction, one of the variables that relates to the management of the cabinet still has a coefficient that is statistically significantly different from zero. With this later wave of data giving the leader the power to allocate portfolios (model 9) is estimated to increase the proportion of citizens satisfied by approximately 1.9 percentage points and is statistically significant at the 5% level ($p = .038$). That estimate is slightly larger than the estimated coefficient associated with leaders having the power to appoint the members of the cabinet (model 10) which is associated with an approximate 1.5 point increase in the proportion of satisfied citizens but is not statistically significant ($p = .098$). In the second wave of data, there is even less evidence that giving leaders individual decision-making discretion pays off, the estimated coefficient is 0.292 ($p = .744$). As with the results from the first wave, when all the institutional indicators are included in model 12, none of the coefficients differ from zero.

In none of the models reported in tables 3 and 4, is the power of individual decision statistically significant although it is always positive; on the other hand, there does appear to be a consistent and positive effect associated with the powers relating to managing cabinets. These models suggest that leaders who are more able to manage their cabinets and by implication their parties or their coalition partners are more able to make citizens satisfied. Those powers which can be used to monitor performance and to ensure that policy programmes are coherent and joined up seem to be of greater importance than individualized decision-making powers.

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Table 4
Disaggregated leadership power and citizen satisfaction 2006 (OLS)

Outcome	Satisfaction 2006			
Model	9	10	11	12
Log population 2006	−0.358 (−0.53)	−0.348 (−0.50)	−0.330 (−0.46)	−0.382 (−0.55)
London	4.364** (2.92)	4.564** (2.91)	4.370** (2.74)	4.440** (2.87)
Deprivation	0.053 (0.65)	0.056 (0.67)	0.037 (0.44)	0.055 (0.68)
Satisfaction 2000	0.210** (3.75)	0.237** (4.02)	0.244** (4.23)	0.215** (3.75)
Satisfaction 2003	1.972** (3.75)	1.804** (3.91)	1.901** (3.9)	1.917** (3.92)
(Satisfaction 2003)^2	−1.131** (−2.82)	−0.943* (−2.17)	−1.015* (−2.42)	−1.086* (−2.45)
Diversity: ethnic	0.370 (0.39)	0.247 (0.27)	0.419 (0.44)	0.317 (0.33)
Diversity: age	0.910 (1.07)	0.818 (0.94)	1.130 (1.33)	0.848 (0.94)
Geographical inequality	0.047 (0.23)	0.026 (0.12)	0.072 (0.34)	0.037 (0.18)
Average CSP 2002−05	0.174* (2.10)	0.181* (2.15)	0.163 (1.89)	0.180* (2.10)
Majority 2006	−0.198 (−0.20)	−0.258 (−0.26)	0.095 (0.1)	−0.334 (−0.33)
Allocate portfolio 2006	1.858* (2.11)			1.604 (1.51)
Select cabinet 2006		1.459 (1.67)		0.469 (0.46)
Decision-making power 2006			0.292 (0.33)	0.301 (0.35)
Constant	26.838* (2.39)	25.417* (2.21)	25.919* (2.30)	26.511* (2.32)
Observed	102	102	102	102
R^2/adjusted	0.55 (robust SE)	0.54 (robust SE)	0.53 (robust SE)	0.54 (robust SE)

Note: OLS, ordinary least squares.
*$p < .05$; **$p < .01$ (t values in parenthesis).

The pattern emerges from both waves of the survey, but more strongly in the first. Indeed, as these models are based on a disaggregation of the leadership variable discussed in table 2, we would also expect to find some decline in the coefficient sizes of the leadership indicators from 2002 to 2006.

CONCLUSIONS

We use variation in the position of leaders in England's top-tier authorities to test the argument that variation in leadership powers produces increased citizen satisfaction at the local level—and by implication at other levels of government. We find that political leaders with greater formal power do tend to produce a higher proportion of satisfied citizen-consumers. Overall, our findings add to the insights from a portion of the literature that sees powers given to single political office holders as a route to more effective policies and delivery. Additionally, strengthening the position of elected leaders may contribute directly to satisfaction. The relationship holds even where a leader's political party does not enjoy an overall majority on the council.

Leadership matters, then. The study both reinforces and extends the analysis produced by Cusack (1999) and Andrews, Boyne, and Enticott (2006), as well as linking to the wider literature on urban reform and political leadership. In contrast to the wave of studies on the impact of the leadership form, we are also able to pin down what exactly it is about leadership that matters. It is the powers to appoint colleagues and allocate portfolios that appears to make the difference, which coheres with a more general understanding of leadership as being effective when there is a close group of supporters doing the leader's bidding and working as a cohesive group. Strong leadership rarely works when there are opponents round

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the cabinet table as accounts of prime ministerial government demonstrate all too well (Pimlott 1993). Picking who you want to occupy the key portfolios helps get the job done and provides a united front to show to the public. The public dislike divided leadership.

The political context—in terms of whether or not a single party has majority control—does not seem to matter so consistently for citizen satisfaction. Citizens are more affected by leaders' powers. They reward strong leaders irrespective as to whether they are the head of the single governing party or a member of a coalition of parties. This appears counter-intuitive: leaders with greater powers should be better able to get their way in majority cabinets, and those leading split cabinets should find greater difficulty using these powers and presenting a united front to the citizenry. But the impact of leadership powers appears to be independent of political context. Leaders in coalitions cabinets can use their powers and influence the electorate just as much as their majority leader colleagues.

It is clear that the relationship is at least partly direct—even though citizens acknowledge local governments for good performance, they also acknowledge the direct contribution of leaders. The strong leader is able to have a stronger direct relationship to the public than the weaker counterpart. Citizens notice these stronger leaders in power and reward them in addition to their contribution to running bureaucracies. Citizen satisfaction then is partly political, it is about the appearance of the local authority in the eyes of the public, and is not just about emptying the bins on time. Such considerations are a tribute to the durability of politics rather than the dominance of questions of efficient management. The reformers of local government recognized the significance of the directly accountable executive and may in part be vindicated by these findings. Institutional rules that change the power of the leader to appoint and to manage cabinets affect citizen satisfaction, even if they are not as dramatic as other constitutional provisions, such as direct election. In addition, it is not just through performance that leaders have an impact; it is directly through to the people. And all this happens in the supposedly invisible world of English local government. In other more politically visible systems, either at the local or at other levels of government, we should expect the adoption of powers of appointment and portfolio allocation to increase the performance and improve the satisfaction of citizens with their governments. Importantly, the powers that we analyze are the ones that are likely to allow leaders to ensure policy is coherent and competently delivered rather than crude discretionary decision-making powers. Our analysis suggests that there are different ways for leaders to be powerful, and an undifferentiated suspicion of concentrated leadership power misses important potential benefits.

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FUNDING

Department for Communities and Local Government.

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